

3.3 The Voice Filter: What Belongs in the Profile

Apply this filter to every trait you identify during the excavation. It keeps your profile lean, voice-focused, and translatable into Dialogue Matrix parameters.

3.3.1 The Four-Gate Checklist

For each trait, ask:

- ☐ Does this trait change how the character **constructs a sentence**? (Length, structure, fragments vs. full thoughts)
- ☐ Does this trait change how the character **selects a word**? (Vocabulary ceiling, register, domain, formality)
- ☐ Does this trait change how the character **modulates their emotional register**? (Temperature, guardedness, leakage, subtext)
- ☐ Does this trait change how the character **sequences their conversational turns**? (Interrupting, trailing off, deflecting, monologuing)

Result:

- **At least one box checked** → This is a **voice trait**. Write it into your voice profile.
- **No boxes checked** → This is a **narration trait**. Move it to your character bible for action beats, body language, and scene description.

3.3.2 Practice Drill: Sort the Trait

Cover the answer column. Make your call. Then check.

Trait	Your Call (Voice / Narration)	Answer and Reasoning
Callum cracks his knuckles before delivering bad news	[YOUR_CALL]	Narration. Physical action beat. Does not reshape sentences, vocabulary, or turn-taking.
Callum drops all contractions when delivering bad news, switching to full formal constructions	[YOUR_CALL]	Voice. The shift from "don't" to "do not" changes vocabulary register and sentence construction.
Mara stares at her shoes when receiving a compliment	[YOUR_CALL]	Narration. Body language. Paints the scene but does not alter the words she produces.

Trait	Your Call (Voice / Narration)	Answer and Reasoning
Mara deflects compliments by immediately asking three questions about the other person	[YOUR_CALL]	Voice. Reshapes conversational turns. She sequences speech differently under the trigger of praise.
Callum's jaw tightens before he forces out an apology	[YOUR_CALL]	Narration. Physical. Belongs in the action beat surrounding the dialogue.
Callum's apologies emerge as two-word fragments: "I'm sorry." No elaboration.	[YOUR_CALL]	Voice. Sentence construction clipped to two words. The brevity is the apology.

Quick rule when in doubt: Could the AI reproduce this in dialogue alone, without any action beats or stage directions? If yes, it is voice. If it requires a body, a room, or a physical gesture to exist, it is narration.

3.3.3 Profile Quality Check

Run this sixty-second check before moving to the stress-test phase.

- ☐ Every trait in my profile passes at least one of the four voice-filter gates.
- ☐ No physical actions, body language, or environmental observations remain in the voice profile.
- ☐ Each layer contains between five and eight entries. (Fewer than five: dig deeper. More than eight: trim to the strongest.)
- ☐ I can read each trait aloud and immediately hear the character's voice shift.
- ☐ The profile exists as a typed or handwritten document, saved and labeled, ready for Chapter 4.